

## 2026-W16 MH@MERICS Weekly Update

### I. HIGHLIGHTS

#### German China policy in context

##### Iran / US

- [US Treasury's Bessent says China has been unreliable partner by hoarding oil during war | Reuters](#)
- [Europe tests 'third way' on Hormuz without the US, Israel and Iran. Will it work? | SCMP](#) including China
- [Iran used Chinese spy satellite to target US bases - FT](#)
- [Saudi Oil Exports to China Set to Halve as Iran War Disrupts Flows - Bloomberg](#)

##### EU

- [Trade in goods with China in 2025 - News articles - Eurostat](#) €359.8 billion deficit. Exports -6.5%, imports +6.4%.
- [EU launches critical minerals procurement platform to cut China dependence | SCMP](#)
- [EU to relax merger rules in bid to create 'European champions' - FT](#)
- [Hungary's PM-elect Magyar sends warm overture to China, vows fair play for firms | SCMP](#) "We want to position Hungarian companies as partners at BYD, CATL and other major investors, and I believe we will be able to cooperate."

##### Pedro Sánchez' China trip

- [Spanish premier urges China to take bigger role in multipolar order | Reuters](#)
- [China Pressures Spain to Oppose EU Plan Favoring Domestic Companies - Bloomberg](#)

### II. SELECTED RESEARCH AND INSIGHTS

*MERICS research and (media) insights | 1. Domestic economic situation/policy | 2. Politics and society | 3. Geoeconomics: trade, tech, finance, investment, industrial policy and competition | 4. Foreign policy / "Global China" | 5. Strategic implications and responses*

#### MERICS research and (media) insights

##### Publications

- [MERICS Europe China 360°: EU Industrial Accelerator Act + Critical materials + Platform exports:](#)
  - The EU's Industrial Accelerator Act won't stave off China's unfair trade practices
  - Europe is running out of time to cut its dependency on China for critical materials
  - Europe-China Diplomatic Tracker: China's diplomatic engagement with Europe has so far remained focused on member states in 2026
  - Soapbox-MERICS Data Highlight: Chinese online platform exports to the EU

- [Four key points to keep in view as China implements its 15th Five-Year Plan](#) (Nis Grünberg, Alexander Davey)
- [Soapbox Issue 243](#) (in cooperation with MERICS):
  - Germany earns from the U.S. and the UK, but “loses” in trade with China (trade balances).
  - EU exports to China are a big-company business.
  - The EU depends overwhelmingly on China for key antibiotics.
  - Orbán’s China bet brought capital, not balanced trade.
  - Spain imports about five euros’ worth from China for every euro it exports there.

### **Briefings & roundtables**

- Together with Stiftung Mercator we organized a roundtable on “Deutsche Green Tech Interessen und China: Balancieren zwischen Chancen, Konkurrenz und Standortpolitik”
- The European Parliament’s INTA committee invited Bernhard Bartsch for a [panel](#) on Economic opportunities, EU leverage and potential cooperation in a public hearing on Trade and Investment Relations with China.
- From Thursday to Friday, we held our 15th [European China Policy Track 1.5 Workshop](#) in Brussels.
- [E-CKN Briefing: China’s “World-Class Military” in the Indo-Pacific: Scenarios for 2049 and their consequences for European security” | Merics](#)

### **Media**

- [Deutschlandfunk](#): Mikko Huotari on China’s role in the Middle East
- [dpa](#) quoted Alexander Brown on possibly decreasing demand for Chinese goods as fallout of the Iran war.
- [Nature](#) asked Rebecca Arcesati on Chinese AI research.

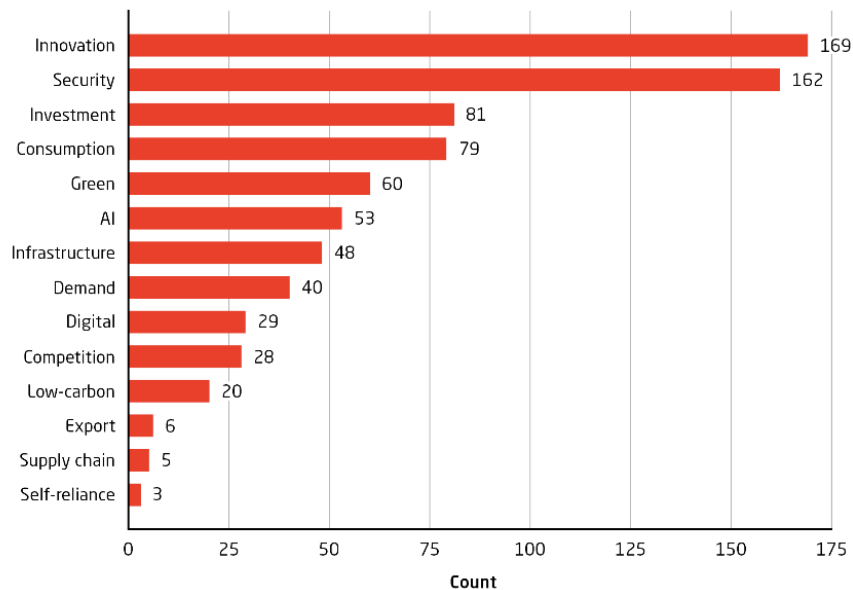
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| <b>Top charts (W16)</b> |
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## Selected terms in China's 15<sup>th</sup> Five-Year Plan

Absolute mentions of key words in the Plan



Panel A. Mentions in the 15<sup>th</sup> Five-Year Plan



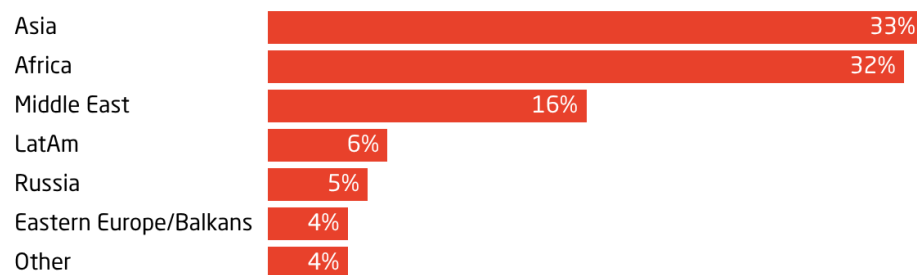
Source: Outline of the 15<sup>th</sup> Five-Year Plan (2026-2030) for National Economic and Social Development of the People's Republic of China

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## China's overseas construction projects shift further toward Asia and Africa



Overseas projects, % change by value, Jan-Feb 2026



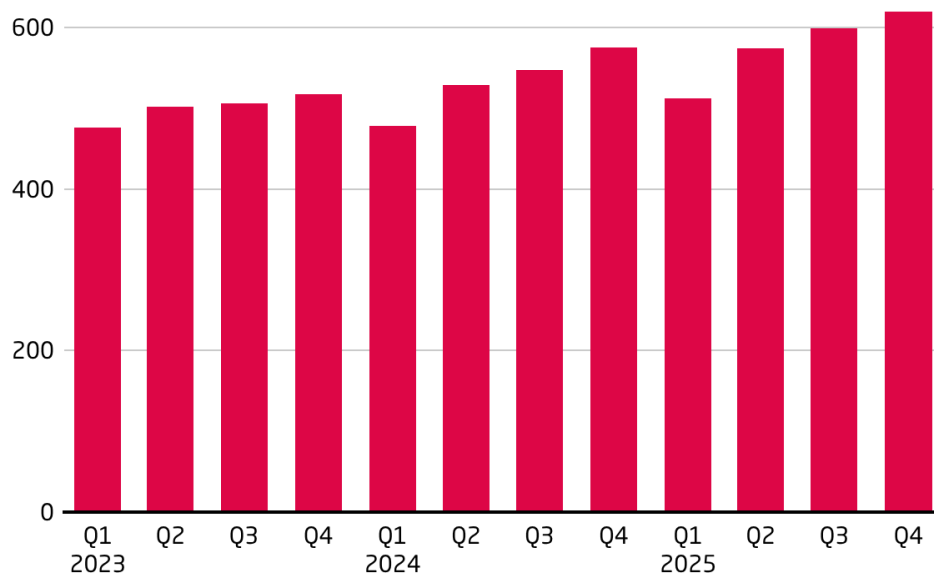
Source: GACC

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(via [Soapbox](#))

## China Machinery & Electronics Exports Hit Quarterly Record

Export value (USD bn)



Source: EAE / China Customs (CCCME, GACC)

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## China supplies the vast majority of Europe's key antibiotics

Share of EU imports sourced in China, % by quantity, 2025



Source: Eurostat

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(via [Soapbox](#))

## Most Americans have an unfavorable view of China, but positive views are increasing



% of U.S. adults who have a(n) \_\_ opinion of China

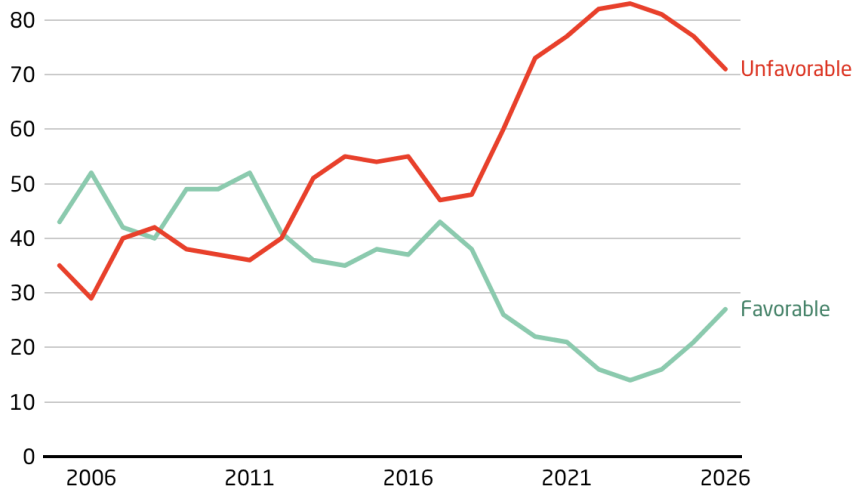


Chart: Note: Those who did not answer are not shown. • Source: Pew Research Center (Survey of U.S. adults, March 23-29, 2026)

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## China's diplomatic engagement with Europe has so far remained focused on member states in 2026



Exchanges between selected Chinese and European leaders (February 1, 2026-April 14, 2026)



**Xi Jinping 习近平**  
General Secretary of the CCP,  
President of the PRC

- 02/25/2026** Receives German Chancellor Merz
- 04/14/2026** Receives Spanish Prime Minister Sanchez



**Li Qiang 李强**  
Premier of the PRC

- 03/25/2026** Call with Dutch Prime Minister Jetten
- 02/25/2026** Meets with German Chancellor Merz
- 04/14/2026** Meets with Spanish Prime Minister Sanchez



**Wang Yi 王毅**  
Director of the CCP's Foreign  
Affairs Commission Office  
and Minister of Foreign  
Affairs of the PRC

- On the sidelines of the Munich Security Conference (MSC):*
- 02/11/2026** Meets Hungarian Prime Minister Orbán and Foreign Minister Szijjártó
  - 02/13/2026** Meets Austrian Foreign Minister Meisl-Reisinger
  - 02/13/2026** Meets French Foreign Minister Barrot
  - 02/13/2026** Meets German Foreign Minister Wadephul
  - 02/13/2026** Tripartite meeting with Barrot and Wadephul
  - 02/13/2026** Meets Serbian President Vučić
  - 02/13/2026** Meets UK Foreign Secretary Cooper
  - 02/13/2026** Meets Ukrainian Foreign Minister Sybiha
  - 02/14/2026** Meets Czech Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Macianka
  - 02/14/2026** Meets German Chancellor Merz
  - 02/14/2026** Meets Norway's Foreign Minister Eide
- Other meetings:*
- 02/13/2026** Call with Dutch Foreign Minister Berendsen
  - 03/02/2026** Call with French Foreign Minister Barrot
  - 03/19/2026** Call with UK Foreign Secretary Cooper
  - 04/02/2026** Call with EU HRVP Kallas
  - 04/02/2026** Call with German Foreign Minister Wadephul

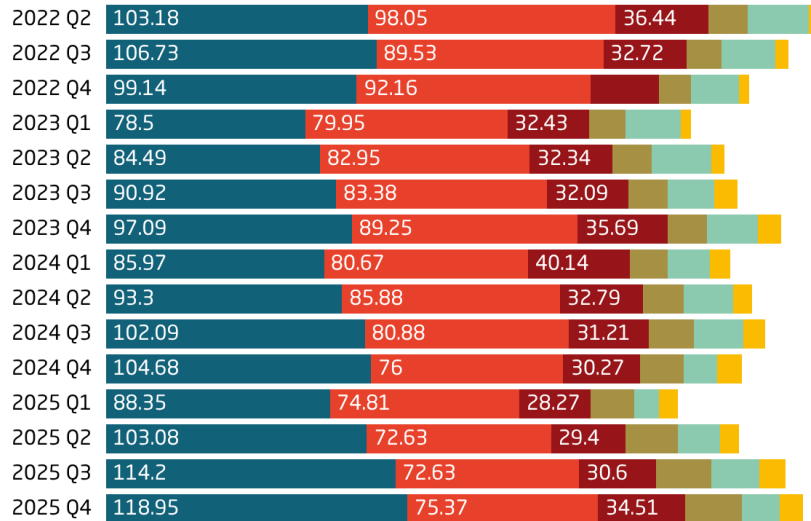
Sources: MERICS on basis of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the PRC

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## China imports by major product, USD bn



■ Semiconductors ■ Crude oil ■ Iron ore ■ Copper ore ■ Grain & food ■ Chip machinery



Source: EAE, CCA, GACC

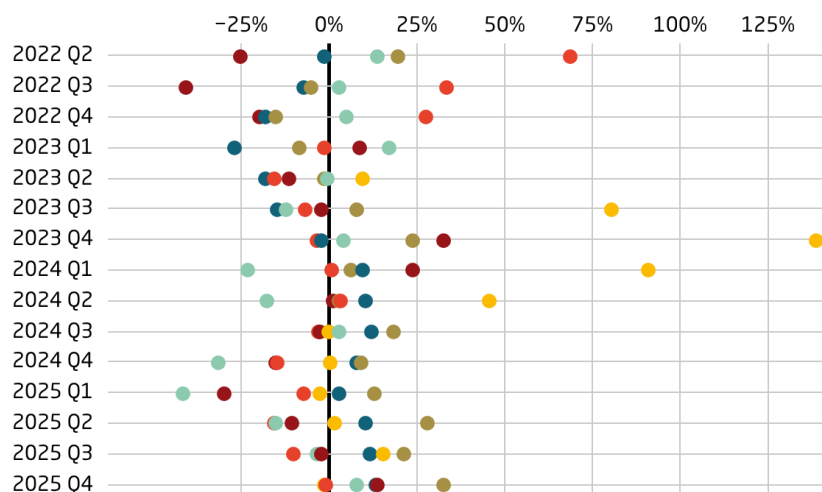
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## Import growth in 2025 mostly driven by ores, semis, chip machinery



China imports by product, quarterly YoY growth (%)

● Semiconductors ● Crude oil ● Iron ore ● Copper ore ● Grain & food ● Chip machinery



Source: EAE, CCA, GACC

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## 1. Domestic economic situation/policy

**WSJ: "China's Economy Starts Year on Strong Footing, but Iran Risks Loom"**, 2026-04-16, <https://www.wsj.com/economy/chinas-growth-accelerated-in-first-quarter-a237034c>

- **China's Q1 2026 GDP grew 5.0%, beating the 4.9% forecast:** Growth accelerated from 4.5% in Q4 2025, driven by resilient exports and front-loaded policy support, according to official NBS data.
- **March data showed broad consumption and trade weakness:** Retail sales rose only 1.7% year-on-year, below the 2.3% forecast, while dollar-denominated exports grew just 2.5% - down sharply from the 22% jump in January-February.
- **Urban unemployment edged up and fixed-asset investment missed targets:** The urban jobless rate rose to 5.4% in March, and fixed-asset investment grew 1.7% in Q1, below the 2.0% expected by economists polled by the WSJ.

**Caixin: "Analysis: Why China's Export Boom Isn't Contributing More to Economic Growth"**, 2026-04-17, <https://www.caixinglobal.com/2026-04-17/analysis-why-chinas-export-boom-isnt-contributing-more-to-economic-growth-102435199.html>

- **China's Q1 GDP grew 5% despite export surge:** Domestic demand accounted for 84.7% of growth, up sharply from 45.2% the prior year, according to the National Bureau of Statistics.
- **Exports rose 14.7% in dollar terms but external demand contributed only 15.3%:** Narrowing imports reduced the trade surplus to \$264.3 billion from \$271.1 billion year-on-year, limiting export-driven GDP impact.

**FT: "China's exports slow as Middle East turmoil weighs on trade"**, 2026-04-14, <https://www.ft.com/content/9cb95187-f525-43a8-bd4d-b631e4da8336>

- **China's March export growth fell sharply to 2.5%, missing forecasts:** The figure fell well short of the 8.6% analyst forecast and the 21.8% recorded in January-February, according to the FT.
- **Imports hit a monthly record, rising 27.8% on higher fuel and tech input costs:** Chip imports were up 45% by value year-to-date, with ING's chief China economist attributing the surge primarily to higher tech product prices rather than energy costs.
- **Middle East turmoil compressed trade with the region in March:** China's customs spokesperson confirmed a decline in trade with the Middle East after growth in the first two months, while Cornell economist Eswar Prasad said global capacity to absorb Chinese exports is "showing signs of wearing thin."

**Caixin: "China's Nuclear Power Investment Hits Record in 2025"**, 2026-04-17, <https://www.caixinglobal.com/2026-04-17/chinas-nuclear-power-investment-hits-record-in-2025-102435178.html>

- **China's nuclear construction investment reached a record 161 billion yuan in 2025:** The figure represents a 10% increase year-on-year, according to a new report cited by Caixin.

- **China operates 59 units and has 35 under construction:** At 41.9 GW of capacity under construction, China is on track to surpass the US as the world's largest nuclear power generator before 2030, the article reports.

**Reuters: "China solar makers say war-induced renewables demand won't fix overcapacity"**, 2026-04-16, <https://www.reuters.com/sustainability/climate-energy/china-solar-makers-say-war-induced-renewables-demand-wont-fix-overcapacity-2026-04-16>

- **Chinese solar capacity covers nearly twice estimated global demand:** Morningstar estimates China's factories could supply roughly double projected global demand in 2026, even accounting for Iran war effects.
- **Front-loaded exports and pricing reforms leave industry in "off-season":** Producers shipped orders early ahead of Beijing's April 1 removal of export tax rebates, while domestic demand is expected to fall following renewable pricing reforms.
- **Europe unlikely to repeat 2022 solar boom, executives say:** European gas prices rose from around 33 to 43 euros per mmBtu since the Iran war began, far below the 2022 surge to 340 euros that drove the previous installation wave.

**Bloomberg: "China Poised to Become Top Tourism Economy as Foreigners Skip US"**, 2026-04-16, <https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2026-04-15/china-poised-to-become-top-tourism-economy-as-foreigners-skip-us>

- **China's tourism economy grew 9.9% in 2025, more than doubling the global rate:** Foreign tourist spending in China rose over 10%, while US inbound visitor spending fell nearly 5%, according to WTTC and Chase Travel data.
- **US tourism contributed \$2.6 trillion to GDP versus China's \$1.8 trillion in 2025:** WTTC CEO Gloria Guevara stated China could close the gap and overtake the US within three to four years at current growth rates.

**Caixin: "China Passenger-Vehicle Sales Slide 22% as Buyers Hold Back"**, 2026-04-14, <https://www.caixinglobal.com/2026-04-13/china-passenger-vehicle-sales-slide-22-as-buyers-hold-back-102433702.html>

- **China's wholesale passenger-vehicle sales fell 22% in Q1 2026:** Sales dropped to 4.2 million units year-on-year as buyers delayed purchases awaiting deeper price cuts and trade-in subsidies, according to Caixin.
- **Oil price surge following Middle East conflict deterred ICE vehicle buyers:** The Digest Hub summary reports 38% of internal combustion engine buyers postponed purchases after Iran blocked the Strait of Hormuz.

## 2. Politics and society

**Nikkei: "Opinion: Beijing has decided it has little to learn from the rest of the world"**, 2026-04-16, <https://asia.nikkei.com/opinion/beijing-has-decided-it-has-little-to-learn-from-the-rest-of-the-world>

- **China Development Forum 2026 signalled tighter capital market controls:** Sideline discussions flagged regulatory moves to discourage overseas listings and renewed questions over the legality of VIE structures, the author reports.



- **Notable Western financial figures declined to attend:** Blackstone's Steve Schwarzman was among prominent absentees, coinciding with China Investment Corp. cutting allocations to US private market firms, according to the article.

**SCMP: "Sour note: China criticises local governments for 'imprudent' spending", 2026-04-15,** <https://www.scmp.com/economy/china-economy/article/3350133/sour-note-china-criticises-local-governments-imprudent-spending>

- **Central government publicly named local authorities for "imprudent" fiscal spending:** Named cases include a poor Sichuan county that spent 1.49 million yuan of transfer payments on three tourism promotion songs.
- **Criticism issued under a February-to-July governance campaign:** Officials at county level and above are required to standardise performance evaluation criteria and tighten procurement, according to Xinhua.

**Foreign Policy: "Why Xi Is Kneecapping His Own Top Men", 2026-04-15,** <https://foreignpolicy.com/2026/04/15/ma-xingrui-xi-china-purges-xinjiang>

- **Ma Xingrui placed under CCDI investigation on April 3, 2026:** The sitting Politburo member and former Xinjiang party secretary was formally investigated for suspected serious violations of discipline and law.
- **The author argues Ma's real offence was building elite networks outside Xi's direct control:** Allegations centre on his wife facilitating offshore insurance policies worth tens of millions of yuan for senior officials' families, forming a protection alliance.
- **The case marks a precedent for purging civilian Politburo incumbents:** The author argues this signals that proximity to Xi - including ties to his wife Peng Liyuan - no longer guarantees political safety.

**Foreign Policy: "Xinjiang Repression Has Evolved Not Ended", 2026-04-16,** <https://foreignpolicy.com/2026/04/16/china-xinjiang-uyghur-camps-repression>

- **Former Xinjiang police officer describes shift to concealed, quota-driven short-term detention:** Zhang Yabo, a Han Chinese ex-officer in Hotan, testifies that from early 2023 authorities imposed fresh detention quotas targeting minor infractions such as missing flag-raising ceremonies.
- **Xinjiang exports to EU, US, UK, and Canada surged 465% under Ma Xingrui's 2021-2025 tenure:** According to official customs data cited in the article, direct exports to those markets rose a further 71% between 2024 and 2025 alone.
- **Author argues repression shifted from visible mass internment to infrastructural bureaucratic control:** Zenz contends Ma replaced campaign-style coercion with normalised forced labour transfers - reaching 3.4 million instances by 2025 - and systematic cultural erasure.

**Hrw: "China: Pressure on Catholics Escalates", 2026-04-16,** <https://www.hrw.org/news/2026/04/15/china-pressure-on-catholics-escalates>

- **HRW documents escalating repression of China's 12 million Catholics:** Authorities have intensified ideological training, surveillance, travel restrictions, and pressure on underground communities to join the state-controlled Patriotic Association.

- **December 2025 regulations require all Catholic clergy to surrender travel documents for state approval:** The rules cover all travel, including personal trips, and formalise existing restrictions on clergy contact with foreign churches and entities.
- **2018 Holy See-China bishop agreement used to coerce underground church compliance:** According to interviewees, authorities cite the agreement to pressure underground clergy to join the official church, with non-compliance resulting in detention, house arrest, or loss of livelihood.

**WSJ: “Opinion: Now China Is Taking Jimmy Lai’s Property”**, 2026-04-17, <https://www.wsj.com/opinion/now-china-is-taking-jimmy-lais-property-bad256ac>

- **Hong Kong authorities filed to seize Jimmy Lai’s assets on 2 April:** The application targets properties linked to his National Security Law conviction, potentially including a \$70 million shareholder loan he made to Next Digital.
- **Authors describe direct experience of government asset seizure:** As former Next Digital directors, they report that a 2021 security order froze Lai’s 71% shareholding and barred use of company funds, leading to Apple Daily’s closure and 800 job losses.

**Economist: “Why China’s government worries about AI”**, 2026-04-16, <https://www.economist.com/china/2026/04/16/why-chinas-government-worries-about-ai>

- **Xi Jinping publicly raised AI job displacement and loss-of-control risks for the first time:** A state think-tank report found the share of workers fearing AI job replacement rose from 49% in 2024 to 59% in 2025.
- **Beijing banned an AI agent from sensitive sectors after data and security incidents:** Authorities restricted “OpenClaw” following reports of data deletion, device takeovers, and hacking vulnerabilities, with regulators ordering safety standards for AI agents.
- **Party adviser confirms technological competition overrides domestic concerns:** If forced to choose, the government will prioritise winning the AI race over public anxiety about jobs or safety, according to a Beijing-based government adviser cited by the article.

**Caixin: “China Unveils National ‘AI+Education’ Plan to Transform Classrooms by 2030”**, 2026-04-16, <https://www.caixinglobal.com/2026-04-16/china-unveils-national-ai-education-plan-to-transform-classrooms-by-2030-102434567.html>

- **China’s “AI+ Education” plan targets full system integration by 2030:** The Ministry of Education and four other bodies jointly issued the action plan on April 8, covering primary schools through lifelong education.
- **Plan includes personalised tutoring, teacher certification, and demographic forecasting:** Officials also aim to use AI to predict population shifts and reallocate educational resources accordingly.

**Caixin: “Standardize EV Batteries, Chips to Help Carmakers Profit, Nio Chief Says”**, 2026-04-13, <https://www.caixinglobal.com/2026-04-13/standardize-ev-batteries-chips-to-help-carmakers-profit-nio-chief-says-102433523.html>

- **Nio CEO called for EV battery and chip standardisation to restore sector profitability:** William Li proposed reducing battery specifications to 4-5 types and

cutting chip variety, arguing the current model shortens peak vehicle sales windows to under a year.

- **Standardisation could save over 100 billion yuan annually, Nio estimates:** Nio's ES9 alone uses over 4,000 chips across more than 1,000 types, with batteries and chips together exceeding 50% of vehicle cost.

### 3. Geoeconomics: trade, tech, finance, investment, industrial policy and competition

**NYT: "China's Electrostare Is Poised to Win From War in the Middle East"**, 2026-04-13, <https://www.nytimes.com/2026/04/13/business/energy-environment/china-energy-battery-grid.html>

- **Chinese firms dominate grid hardware as war accelerates renewable demand:** Chinese companies manufacture nearly every component of a modern grid, including solar panels, cables, transformers, and batteries, the article reports.
- **Global battery storage shipments nearly doubled in Q1 2026:** BofA Global Research head of Asia-Pacific research Matty Zhao attributed the surge to accelerating grid investment driven by Middle East supply disruptions.
- **Chinese firms raising capital in Hong Kong to fund overseas expansion:** CATL, Sungrow, Ningbo Deye, and Sieyuan have listed or applied to list in Hong Kong to finance plants in Europe and beyond.

**WSJ: "An Iran War Winner: China's Green Industrial Complex"**, 2026-04-13, <https://www.wsj.com/business/energy-oil/an-iran-war-winner-chinas-green-industrial-complex-1ef8a2bc>

- **Iran war disruptions accelerating global demand for Chinese clean tech:** China accounts for roughly four-fifths of solar manufacturing and over 70% of EV production, according to the IEA.
- **Chinese clean energy exports surged in March:** EV exports more than doubled year-on-year and one Qingdao exporter reported sales tripling, the article reports.
- **Security concerns persist alongside growing dependence on China:** European and US policymakers worry about remote-disabling of connected devices, and Beijing's rare-earth export restrictions demonstrated its willingness to use market leverage, the article notes.

**CFR: "With Hormuz Closed China Is Wiring the Globes Clean Energy Future"**, 2026-04-16, <https://www.cfr.org/articles/with-hormuz-closed-china-is-wiring-the-globes-clean-energy-future>

- **Iran war accelerates global demand for Chinese clean energy exports:** Nations hit by the Hormuz blockage are fast-tracking renewable projects, deepening dependence on China's dominant solar, battery, and EV industries, the author reports.
- **China holds 60% of global aluminum production and 70% average market share in 19 critical mineral refining categories:** Gulf aluminum exports have been disrupted by the war, the article notes, further consolidating China's supplier leverage.
- **Trump administration policy cuts weaken US competitiveness in the energy transition:** The author argues proposed reductions to federal energy R&D and

renewable tax incentives leave the US poorly positioned to counter China's electrostate model.

**Bloomberg: "China's Battery Exports Surge as War Drives Energy-Supply Crunch",** 2026-04-14, <https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2026-04-14/china-s-battery-exports-surge-as-war-drives-energy-supply-crunch>

- **China's lithium battery exports rose 50% year-on-year in Q1 2026:** Growth accelerated from 26% for full-year 2025, partly driven by front-loading ahead of an export-tax rebate cut from 9% to 6% on April 1.
- **Ningbo Deye Technology reported up to 70% Q1 profit growth:** The battery storage manufacturer cited a notable increase in orders from Europe, the Middle East, and Southeast Asia following Middle East war-driven energy disruptions.

**Semafor: "How China is winning the global energy war",** 2026-04-14, <https://www.semafor.com/article/04/14/2026/the-iran-war-sent-energy-prices-soaring-china-is-stepping-in>

- **Chinese turbine manufacturer Goldwind underbid European rivals by 20-40% in Egypt:** Infinity Power's chairman said Goldwind offered wind turbines at under \$800,000 per megawatt versus \$980,000-\$1.2 million from Vestas and Siemens.
- **Iran war energy disruptions are accelerating Chinese clean-tech penetration in the Global South:** Egypt's gas import bill more than doubled from January to March, pushing the country toward a Chinese-backed renewables buildout targeting 45% renewable electricity within two years.
- **PowerChina is building its third Egyptian wind project as overseas demand outpaces company capacity:** The firm's Egypt director said Chinese contractors hold a structural cost advantage through privileged access to upstream Chinese suppliers, effectively foreclosing competition from Western rivals.

**Caixin: "U.S. and China Reach Near-Parity in AI Model Performance, Report Finds",** 2026-04-15, <https://www.caixinglobal.com/2026-04-14/us-and-china-reach-near-parity-in-ai-model-performance-report-finds-102434062.html>

- **Stanford report finds US-China top AI model gap narrowed to 2.7%:** Claude Opus 4.6 led China's Dola-Seed-2.0 by 2.7 points on the benchmark leaderboard as of March 2026, per the Stanford 2026 AI Index Report.
- **China leads in publications, US in models and private investment:** China accounted for 41% of top 100 cited AI papers in 2024 while the US produced 50 notable models versus China's 30 and attracted \$285.9 billion in private AI investment.
- **US AI talent inflows fell 80% in 2025, hitting a decade low:** Researcher and developer relocations to the US dropped 89% since 2017, with the steepest single-year decline recorded in 2025, according to the report.

**SCMP: "China's AI firms scaled up on open-source models. The next phase may be different",** 2026-04-17, <https://www.scmp.com/tech/tech-trends/article/3350340/chinas-ai-firms-scaled-open-source-models-next-phase-may-be-different>

- **China's AI firms built scale on free open-source models:** Alibaba's Qwen model reached nearly 1 billion cumulative downloads over three years, making it the most downloaded open-source AI model family globally.

- **Thin margins are pushing firms toward hybrid monetisation strategies:** Alibaba's Joe Tsai acknowledged the company does not make money from its AI models directly, with revenue derived instead from cloud and inference services.

**SCMP: "China doubles 'AI for science' computing scale in 2 months using no US chips"**, 2026-04-16, <https://www.scmp.com/news/china/science/article/3350208/china-doubles-ai-science-computing-scale-2-months-using-no-us-chips>

- **China's Zhengzhou AI computing node doubled chip count to 60,000 units:** The cluster, using Sugon-made accelerators with no US chips, reached full operation on 16 April, CCTV reported.
- **Node declared China's most powerful scientific AI computing infrastructure:** CCTV described the expansion as "a breakthrough" for AI-driven research computing, citing advantages for industrial AI applications.

**SCMP: "How a Chinese company said it used AI to track US bomber movements over Iran"**, 2026-04-13, <https://www.scmp.com/news/china/military/article/3349788/how-chinese-company-said-it-used-ai-track-us-bomber-movements-over-iran>

- **Chinese geospatial firm used AI to map US bomber strike patterns over Iran:** MizarVision published a report correlating KC-135 and KC-46 tanker ADS-B signals with known US strikes on Iranian targets.
- **Firm combined signal tracking with satellite imagery across the Middle East:** A prior month-long monitoring effort documented US military asset deployments, though the precise role of AI in the analysis was unclear, according to SCMP.

**FT: "Inside China's probe of Meta's 'conspiratorial' \$2bn Manus deal"**, 2026-04-17, <https://www.ft.com/content/30383351-763e-4863-a8aa-12cac1dec4c2>

- **China's National Security Commission branded Meta's Manus acquisition "conspiratorial":** The Xi-chaired body circulated its assessment among senior leaders, triggering a multi-agency review involving NDRC, the commerce ministry, and the antitrust watchdog.
- **Manus co-founders barred from leaving China after NDRC summons:** Officials are examining potential violations of foreign investment and export control rules, and some Chinese investors have held preliminary talks about unwinding the deal.
- **Regulators reversed an earlier clearance of Manus's Singapore relocation:** Officials who had previously found no breach of export controls are now under pressure to "correct" that judgment following the National Security Commission's intervention.

**FT: "Opinion: What's really shocking about the second China shock?"**, 2026-04-16, <https://www.ft.com/content/4687462f-dc46-4d39-a6a7-b74e5810a03a>

- **China's current account surplus rose a similar share of global GDP in both shock periods:** In absolute export volume terms, the two shocks are also broadly comparable, despite the first shock appearing larger relative to China's own GDP.
- **Second shock differs in product mix and price dynamics:** China's export prices fell sharply after 2018 - reaching 2018 levels by 2025 - while first-shock exports concentrated in low-tech goods whose prices rose 40% between 2000 and 2007.
- **US policy divergence and reduced import demand mark the second shock:** China's import volumes have been anaemic compared to the first shock period, and

the US share of Chinese exports has fallen six percentage points since 2018 - three times the first-shock decline.

**Caixin: “China’s Machinery, Electronics Exports Hit Record in First Quarter”**, 2026-04-16, <https://www.caixinglobal.com/2026-04-16/chinas-machinery-electronics-exports-hit-record-in-first-quarter-102434435.html>

- **China’s machinery and electronics exports hit a record \$620bn in Q1 2026:** Year-on-year growth of 21.4% was driven by integrated circuits, up 77.5% to \$72.5bn, and vehicles, up 58.5% to \$40.8bn.
- **Pre-tariff frontloading and government trade promotion boosted sector growth:** The 21.4% rise far exceeded the sector’s 8.4% compound annual growth rate during the 14th Five-Year Plan period, according to a China Chamber of Commerce spokesperson.
- **Mobile phone exports fell 4.7% to \$26.6bn:** Apple’s production shift to India - reducing supply chain exposure to US tariffs - accounted for a significant share of the decline, the article reports.

**FT: “China flexes trade power with soaring use of export controls”**, 2026-04-14, <https://www.ft.com/content/a2d7601a-dd2a-4619-ae08-321489f84d23>

- **China tripled export control use over five years, EU Chamber reports:** Beijing imposed trade restrictions 30 times between 2021 and 2025, up from 11 in the preceding five-year period.
- **New supply chain regulations criminalise due diligence by foreign firms:** Rules signed by Premier Li Qiang and effective 31 March allow exit bans on individuals who gather supply chain information or disrupt transactions with Chinese counterparties.
- **EU Chamber warns new rules conflict with European supply chain audit directives:** President Eskelund said information collected to comply with EU law risks being interpreted as a violation of Chinese regulations.

**NYT: “China Imposes New Rules to Block Foreign Companies From ‘Decoupling’”**, 2026-04-14, <https://www.nytimes.com/2026/04/14/business/china-foreign-companies-supply-chain.html>

- **China enacted 18-point supply chain rules barring companies from decoupling:** Regulations signed by Premier Li Qiang on April 7 allow authorities to question employees, examine records, and impose exit bans on individuals suspected of shifting supply chains under foreign pressure.
- **EU and US business chambers warned of legal overreach and further de-risking:** The EU Chamber’s Jens Eskelund cited the lack of transparent legal process; AmCham president Michael Hart warned the rules could accelerate foreign firms’ withdrawal from China.
- **New rules follow and extend Beijing’s existing Xinjiang enforcement toolkit:** China’s 2024 investigation into PVH for avoiding Xinjiang suppliers is cited as a precedent the new regulations build upon.



**WSJ: “China Sharpens Retaliatory Tools Against U.S. Ahead of Trump Summit”**, 2026-04-15, <https://www.wsj.com/world/china/china-sharpens-retaliatory-tools-against-u-s-ahead-of-trump-summit-6a3168bc>

- **Beijing released two sets of retaliatory legal tools ahead of Trump’s May visit:** Regulations dated March 31 empower authorities to penalise foreign firms that drop Chinese suppliers or threaten China’s resource access, with restrictions on business, investment, and travel.
- **A separate 20-point ruleset targets “unjustified extraterritorial jurisdiction”:** Offending foreign entities face addition to a “malicious entity list,” with penalties including asset seizures, expulsion, and entry bans, according to the article.
- **Vague provisions leave foreign firms exposed to dual compliance risk:** The EU Chamber of Commerce warned that broad definitions could render legitimate commercial decisions subject to Beijing’s penalties.

**FT: “As Trump scares off US scientists, China is racing ahead”**, 2026-04-15, <https://www.ft.com/content/47c7d3fa-d947-488e-9f1c-5e51e3d631ff>

- **China’s R&D spending overtook the US in 2024:** OECD data shows China spent \$1.03tn against the US’s \$1.01tn, after a sixfold increase in R&D expenditure between 2007 and 2023.
- **Chinese research vessels reportedly mapping strategically sensitive ocean floors:** Reuters analysis of ship-tracking data and state media concluded that vessels in the Arctic, Pacific and Indian oceans are collecting subsea terrain data with potential military applications.
- **China supplied a third of new drugs licensed by major US firms in Q1 2025:** The article reports this as evidence that China is now a net exporter of innovation in sectors including biotech and green tech.

**FT: “Tropical Chinese island bids to be world’s largest free-trade hub”**, 2026-04-13, <https://www.ft.com/content/df99ad23-1cd6-41db-acb3-f8b5a6e5e131>

- **Hainan completed customs separation from mainland China in December:** The island scrapped most import tariffs and allows value-added goods to be re-exported to the mainland duty-free after 30% processing.
- **Early results modest; structural critics question viability:** Officials reported Rmb129mn in duty savings and 5,700 new trade registrations in the first six weeks, but analysts cite limited port infrastructure and distance from mainland supply chains as constraints.
- **Hainan pitches financial services and medical tourism alongside manufacturing:** The province has introduced China’s lowest income tax cap at 15% and looser fund licensing rules, targeting Singapore and Hong Kong-based investors.

**WSJ: “Big Pharma Is Turning to China for the Newest Drug Ideas”**, 2026-04-13, <https://www.wsj.com/health/pharma/pfizer-biotech-china-glubio-molecular-glue-dd938650>

- **Western and Japanese drugmakers spent \$5.6 billion on 70 Chinese biotech deals in 2025:** Pfizer, Gilead, and Sanofi are among companies licensing Chinese-originated drug candidates, according to pharmaceutical intelligence firm Evaluate.
- **China accounted for 30% of the global experimental drug pipeline last year:** McKinsey data cited in the article attributes this to state investment in research

infrastructure and a regulatory system enabling faster clinical trial approvals than in the US or Europe.

- **Chinese biotechs reverse-engineer Western patents to accelerate drug development:** GluBio used Bristol-Myers and Novartis molecular glue patent filings to improve its own compounds, attracting a \$30 million equity investment from Sanofi.

**SCMP: “EU tests of China’s C919 speed up as pilots stay in Shanghai ‘permanently’ sources”,** 2026-04-13, <https://www.scmp.com/economy/china-economy/article/3349669/eu-tests-chinas-c919-speed-pilots-stay-shanghai-permanently-sources>

- **EASA pilots based permanently in Shanghai for C919 flight tests:** Testing has reached the third of four certification stages, with first test flights conducted in November, according to multiple sources.
- **Chinese airlines supplying live and historical maintenance data to EASA:** China Eastern shared repair records from A and B checks on C919s in service since 2023 to support the certification process.

**Reuters: “China’s Chery looking to expand car production in Europe, top executives say”,** 2026-04-13, <https://www.reuters.com/business/autos-transportation/chinas-chery-looking-expand-car-production-europe-top-executives-say-2026-04-12>

- **Chery seeks European production partnerships to sidestep new capacity costs:** Chairman Yin Tongyue said the company prefers using existing partner factories over building new assembly plants, with announcements expected within months.
- **European sales grew nearly six-fold in 2025, but tariffs require local content solutions:** Chery sold 120,147 vehicles in Europe last year and executives said its Barcelona joint venture - targeting 200,000 units by 2029 - will not alone meet demand or EU local-content requirements.

**FT: “Opinion: Battery giant CATL is no longer just a play on electric vehicles”,** 2026-04-14, <https://www.ft.com/content/561260cd-bea0-421c-bbce-babed3d4cf7b>

- **CATL expanding into energy storage and maritime electrification beyond EVs:** The company has deployed batteries on around 900 vessels and holds over 40% of the global EV battery market, according to the FT.
- **Non-automotive growth shifts CATL toward policy-driven, stable revenue streams:** Energy storage and shipping contracts involve long-term customer integration, offering lower but steadier margins than cyclical EV sales, the article reports.

**Bloomberg: “China’s Control Over Tech Is Threatening India’s Manufacturing Dreams”,** 2026-04-15, <https://www.bloomberg.com/news/features/2026-04-14/china-s-controls-on-battery-ev-tech-hurt-india-s-manufacturing-ambitions>

- **China’s export controls on battery technology blocked Reliance’s gigafactory launch:** Machinery worth up to \$1.1 billion sits warehoused in Jamnagar unable to enter production without further Chinese technology access.
- **India’s 178 GWh battery capacity target is largely unmet:** Commissioned capacity stands at 40 GWh; actual operational output under the government’s PLI scheme is 1 GWh, according to the article.



- **Indian firms pivoting to South Korea and Japan face higher costs and longer timelines:** JSW's technology talks with Gotion stalled, and Tata's Agratas turned to South Korea after early signs of Beijing's export restrictions.

**WSJ: "Battery Maker CATL's Profit Climbs Despite Slowing China EV Sales"**, 2026-04-16, <https://www.wsj.com/business/earnings/battery-maker-cats-profit-climbs-despite-slowing-china-ev-sales-e0bf7c80>

- **CATL Q1 net profit rose 48.5% to 20.74 billion yuan:** Revenue climbed 52.5% to 129.13 billion yuan despite subsidy changes dampening Chinese EV battery demand.
- **CATL plans a \$600 million acquisition of a 49% stake in Hangzhou Zhongheng Electric:** The move targets data-centre power infrastructure, expanding beyond EV batteries into AI-driven energy systems.
- **Analysts cite CATL's 30% energy storage market share as a key growth asset:** HSBC and Bernstein highlight energy storage and cost pass-through capacity as buffers against lithium and copper price pressures.

**FT: "China's battery champion pushes deeper into mining"**, 2026-04-16, <https://www.ft.com/content/d3d721cf-7f38-4d39-ac31-995697d6e8c3>

- **CATL launched a dedicated mining subsidiary with Rmb30bn registered capital:** Shidai Resources Group will pursue domestic and international mineral resource projects to secure raw material supply chains, the company said.
- **Q1 revenue rose 52% to Rmb129.1bn, net profit up 48%:** Results exceeded analyst forecasts, with energy storage systems - including for AI data centres - offsetting slowing Chinese EV demand growth.

**Nikkei: "China snaps up US chip tools via Southeast Asia amid supply chain shift"**, 2026-04-15, <https://asia.nikkei.com/business/technology/tech-asia/china-snaps-up-us-chip-tools-via-southeast-asia-amid-supply-chain-shift>

- **China's chip tool imports from Singapore and Malaysia hit record highs in 2025:** Singapore reached \$5.7 billion (up 17%) and Malaysia \$3.4 billion (more than doubling), as US firms manufacture locally to serve Chinese clients, according to Nikkei Asia's customs data analysis.
- **Direct US chip tool exports to China fell 34% to \$2 billion**, the lowest since 2017, yet Applied Materials, Lam Research and KLA each still derived over 30% of fiscal 2025 revenues from China.
- **US bipartisan MATCH Act introduced in April to tighten multilateral export controls:** The bill targets critical chipmaking machinery and components and would apply pressure on allies - including the Netherlands and Japan - to align restrictions covering SMIC, YMTC, CXMT and Hua Hong.

**Reuters: "Chinese chipmaker YMTC plans new factories amid heightened US-Sino trade tensions, sources say"**, 2026-04-14, <https://www.reuters.com/world/china/chinese-chipmaker-ymtc-plans-new-factories-amid-heightened-us-sino-trade-2026-04-14>

- **YMTC plans three new fabs totalling 300,000 wafers per month:** The three plants would more than double current capacity of 200,000 wafers per month, according to sources cited by Reuters.

- **Over 50% of equipment in the near-complete third fab sourced domestically:** YMTC has deepened ties with suppliers such as AMEC since its Entity List designation in December 2022.
- **YMTC held 11.8% of global NAND flash market in 2025:** UBS projects its share will exceed 14% by early 2027, putting it ahead of Sandisk and approaching SK Hynix, Kioxia, and Micron.

**SCMP: “Semiconductor leap: China looks to next-gen ‘2D chip’ with 1,000-fold growth speed”,** 2026-04-13, <https://www.scmp.com/news/china/science/article/3349677/semiconductor-leap-china-looks-next-gen-2d-chip-1000-fold-growth-speed>

- **Chinese scientists claim a 1,000-fold speed increase in 2D semiconductor growth:** Researchers at the National University of Defence Technology developed a wafer-scale growth method for next-generation chip materials, according to SCMP.
- **Lack of stable p-type 2D semiconductors identified as the critical bottleneck:** High-performance p-type materials are required alongside n-type ones for transistors to function, blocking progress toward sub-5-nm node chips.

**Reuters: “How China is plugging energy supply gaps left by US-Iran conflict”,** 2026-04-14, <https://www.reuters.com/markets/commodities/how-china-is-plugging-energy-supply-gaps-left-by-us-iran-conflict-2026-04-14>

- **China’s Middle East crude imports fell 28% in Jan-May 2026:** The Middle East’s share of China’s total oil imports dropped from 52% in 2025 to 31% in May, according to Kpler data cited by Reuters.
- **Brazil and Russia partially offset Middle East shortfall:** China increased crude imports from South America and Eastern Europe, but total oil imports remain down roughly 10% year-on-year through May.
- **LNG and LPG imports from the Middle East dropped 43%:** China’s total gas imports from all other regions fell only 12% over the same period, indicating the Middle East closure as the primary driver of the shortfall.

**SCMP: “Brazil demands rare earths be processed at home as US and China compete”,** 2026-04-15, <https://www.scmp.com/news/china/article/3350094/brazil-demands-rare-earths-be-processed-home-us-and-china-compete>

- **Brazil requires domestic rare earth processing as condition for foreign access:** A senior industry ministry official said all foreign partners - including Chinese and US firms - must commit to in-country processing and job creation.
- **Brazil holds the world’s second-largest rare earth reserves:** The country accounts for roughly 10% of global critical mineral reserves, also ranking second in graphite and third in nickel.

**Reuters: “China weighs curbs on exports of solar manufacturing equipment to US”,** 2026-04-15, <https://www.reuters.com/legal/litigation/china-weighs-curbs-exports-solar-manufacturing-equipment-us-2026-04-15>

- **Beijing in early talks to restrict solar equipment exports to the US:** Five sources told Reuters that Chinese officials consulted equipment makers on limiting advanced solar manufacturing technology exports, with no rule yet finalised.

- **Tesla's \$2.9 billion equipment order from Chinese suppliers triggered regulatory scrutiny:** Suzhou Maxwell Technologies was visited by officials after Reuters reported on Tesla's purchase plans, with talks focusing on curbs covering high-efficiency HJT panel technology.
- **Potential controls would extend Beijing's tech-leverage playbook beyond rare earths:** The move would follow China's 2025 rare earth export restrictions and could threaten US firms' solar factory expansion plans, according to Reuters.

#### 4. Foreign policy / "Global China"

NYT: "Trump's Blockade Risks Upending an Emerging Détente With China", 2026-04-15, <https://www.nytimes.com/2026/04/14/us/politics/trump-iran-blockade-china.html>

- **US blockade of Iranian oil threatens Trump's planned Beijing summit:** China bought 90% of Iranian crude - over 1.3 million barrels per day - before the February 28 US-Israeli attack began, giving Beijing direct exposure to the blockade.
- **Xi Jinping broke his silence on the war, criticising "law of the jungle" conduct:** Speaking to Abu Dhabi's crown prince, Xi avoided naming the US but China's foreign ministry separately accused Washington of aggravating confrontation and jeopardising Hormuz passage.
- **Intelligence reports of Chinese missile shipments to Iran add a second pressure point:** Trump publicly dismissed the reports but warned of 50% tariffs if confirmed, while analysts note the conflict threatens to derail pre-summit trade deal talks brokered by Bessent.

NYT: "Xi Offers Veiled Critique of U.S. in Rare Comments on War in Iran", 2026-04-15, <https://www.nytimes.com/2026/04/14/world/middleeast/xi-iran-war-china.html>

- **Xi issued his most direct public criticism of US conduct in the Iran war:** Speaking with Abu Dhabi's crown prince, Xi warned against reverting to "the law of the jungle" and selectively applying international law.
- **Wang Yi pressed Pakistan to sustain ceasefire momentum after talks failed:** China's foreign minister also told UAE's special envoy that Beijing was actively pushing for a return to peace in the region.
- **Hormuz dependence is driving China's diplomatic escalation:** According to a Shanghai International Studies University professor, up to 40% of China's oil imports transit the strait, making early cessation of hostilities Beijing's central objective.

NYT: "Why China Won't Lean Hard on Iran", 2026-04-17, <https://www.nytimes.com/2026/04/16/world/asia/china-iran-trump-diplomacy-hormuz.html>

- **Beijing's four-point Iran peace plan offers no binding commitments:** Xi Jinping's proposal calls only for sovereignty and international law to be respected, stopping short of pressure on Tehran to accept US demands.
- **China declines to leverage its position as Iran's largest trading partner:** Officials and analysts cited in the article say Beijing deliberately avoids entanglement, fearing blame if mediation fails and prioritising its Xi-Trump summit reset.
- **Wang Yi urged Hormuz reopening while affirming continued support for Iran:** China's foreign minister called for freedom of navigation to be "guaranteed" but did not condition support on Iranian compliance.

**Bloomberg: “Opinion: The Hormuz Blockade Is as Much About China as Iran”,** 2026-04-14, <https://www.bloomberg.com/opinion/articles/2026-04-14/the-hormuz-blockade-is-as-much-about-china-as-iran>

- **Iran earned an estimated \$175mn/day in oil revenue since the war began:** The author calculates this is up from \$100mn/day pre-war, partly because the White House temporarily lifted sanctions on Iranian barrels.
- **China bought 95% of Iranian crude exports pre-war:** A US blockade of Iranian ports would deprive China of roughly 11% of its total oil imports, forcing drawdowns from strategic petroleum reserves.
- **Author argues China can absorb a two-month embargo at low cost:** With over one billion barrels in reserve, Beijing would deplete only around 10% of its emergency stockpile, limiting Washington’s leverage.

**Bloomberg: “China Urges Restraint as Trump Threatens to Blockade Hormuz”,** 2026-04-13, <https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2026-04-13/china-urges-restraint-as-trump-threatens-to-blockade-hormuz>

- **China called for a Hormuz ceasefire without naming the US:** Foreign Ministry spokesman Guo Jiakun urged “calm and restraint” and said China is willing to play “a positive and constructive role.”
- **Beijing denied CNN-reported plans to supply Iran with MANPADS:** Guo dismissed allegations of arms transfers as “ill-intended” and “groundless smearing,” citing China’s “strict regulation” of defence exports.
- **Trump’s 50% tariff threat on Iran arms suppliers drew a standard Chinese rebuttal:** Guo repeated Beijing’s position that there are no winners in a trade war, without directly addressing the tariff warning.

**SCMP: “China’s Wang Yi calls on Iran to ensure freedom and safe passage through Strait of Hormuz”,** 2026-04-16, <https://www.scmp.com/news/china/diplomacy/article/3350259/chinas-wang-yi-calls-iran-ensure-freedom-and-safe-passage-through-strait-hormuz>

- **Wang Yi pressed Iran to guarantee Hormuz freedom of navigation:** In a phone call with Araghchi, China’s foreign minister said the situation had reached a “critical stage of transition between conflict and peace.”
- **Araghchi asked China to play an active role in ending the conflict:** Tehran indicated willingness to pursue a “rational and realistic solution through peaceful negotiations,” according to the Chinese foreign ministry statement.

**NYT: “U.S. Intelligence Shows China Taking a More Active Role in Iran War”,** 2026-04-13, <https://www.nytimes.com/2026/04/11/us/politics/china-iran-war-missiles-supplies.html>

- **US intelligence assessed possible Chinese shoulder-fired missile shipments to Iran:** The information is not definitive, and China’s embassy denied any weapons transfer, according to US officials cited by the NYT.
- **Beijing is reportedly allowing firms to supply chemicals, fuel and dual-use components to Iran:** US intelligence agencies assess this as active, if covert, support - mirroring China’s dual-use supply approach during Russia’s war in Ukraine.

- **China's Gulf economic ties constrain open Iran support:** A CSIS analyst told the NYT that China's energy and trade relationships with Arab Gulf states are more strategically significant than its ties with Tehran.

**Nikkei: "US-sanctioned Chinese tanker transits Strait of Hormuz hours after blockade"**, 2026-04-14, <https://asia.nikkei.com/spotlight/iran-tensions/iran-war/us-sanctioned-chinese-tanker-transits-strait-of-hormuz-hours-after-blockade>

- **US-sanctioned Chinese tanker exited the Persian Gulf after blockade began:** The Rich Starry, blacklisted in 2023 for carrying Iranian oil, transited Hormuz on Tuesday carrying methanol loaded off the UAE coast.
- **Chinese shipping lawyer disputed the blockade's practical effect:** Wang Muxi argued Iran retains control of the strait, allowing Chinese vessels to transit without difficulty.

**Reuters: "Opinion: China changes tactics on Taiwan and Japan amid Middle East chaos"**, 2026-04-17, <https://www.reuters.com/world/amid-middle-east-chaos-china-changes-tactics-taiwan-japan-2026-04-16>

- **Beijing reframes Taiwan timeline around 2028 KMT election victory:** The author argues China has shifted its primary Taiwan narrative away from a 2027 invasion readiness window toward influencing the island's next election.
- **New KMT leader pledged to invite Xi to Taiwan if elected:** At a promoted Beijing meeting, Kuomintang chair Cheng Li-wun offered the invitation, while the DPP government monitors a stalled Trump-Xi summit for signals on U.S. support.
- **China escalates pressure on Japan while pursuing global broker role:** Beijing hosted Lavrov, Sanchez, and Gulf leaders in one week while simultaneously intensifying military and diplomatic friction with Tokyo over Taiwan-related statements by Prime Minister Takaichi.

**Atlantic Council: "What the KMT Visit Means for Taipei Beijing and Washington"**, 2026-04-14, <https://www.atlanticcouncil.org/dispatches/what-the-taiwanese-opposition-leaders-recent-china-visit-means-for-taipei-beijing-and-washington>

- **Xi met KMT chair Cheng Li-wun in Beijing on April 10, the first such visit since 2016:** Xi presented a four-point proposal calling for cross-strait unity, invoking the "1992 Consensus" while avoiding explicit "One Country, Two Systems" language.
- **Beijing announced ten cross-strait liberalisation measures the following day:** The package covered tourism, agriculture, and fisheries - timed to coincide with Cheng's return to Taipei, the article reports.
- **Cheng's call for "institutional arrangements" signals reduced emphasis on defence:** The article argues this stance aligns with Beijing's demand to oppose foreign interference and could weaken support for Taiwan's \$40 billion defence budget in the legislature.

**FT: "China open to Taiwanese TV and imports after opposition visit"**, 2026-04-13, <https://www.ft.com/content/22ceb574-59da-4bf2-8325-28f6a16e006f>

- **China issued a 10-point plan after Xi-KMT leader meeting:** Beijing pledged to resume direct cross-strait flights, allow Taiwanese TV drama imports, and facilitate agricultural and fishery trade.



- **Crisis Group analyst links concessions to Trump summit timing:** According to William Yang, Beijing aims to influence Trump's stance on US arms sales to Taiwan ahead of a mid-May Xi-Trump summit.

**Reuters: "China turns Taiwan's own voices against it in information war"**, 2026-04-17, <https://www.reuters.com/world/china/china-turns-taiwans-own-voices-against-it-information-war-2026-04-17>

- **Chinese state media dramatically scaled up use of Taiwanese voices:** IORG data show 560,000 videos posted by 1,076 CCP-run Douyin accounts in Q4 2025, with clips featuring Taiwanese figures more than doubling year-on-year.
- **KMT leader Cheng Li-wun was the top target of amplification:** She appeared in 460 videos across 68 Douyin accounts, generating over five million interactions, with clips later repackaged for Facebook, TikTok and YouTube.
- **Campaign aims partly to undermine Taiwan's \$40 billion defence spending push:** According to IORG and three Taiwanese security officials, Beijing seeks to convince Taiwanese that resisting Chinese military power is futile.

**Nikkei: "Military purges prompted Xi Jinping to meet Taiwan KMT leader"**, 2026-04-16, <https://asia.nikkei.com/editor-s-picks/china-up-close/analysis-military-purges-prompted-xi-jinping-to-meet-taiwan-kmt-leader>

- **PLA purges left CMC reduced to two members by April 2026:** All CMC members except Xi and Zhang Shengmin have been purged, the author reports, leaving senior military commands understaffed and undertrained.
- **Xi-Cheng meeting timed to deflect attention from military disarray:** The author argues Beijing accelerated the invitation to KMT chair Cheng Li-wun after the January 2026 purge of CMC vice chairman Zhang Youxia, Xi's long-trusted ally.
- **Xi-KMT summit first CCP-KMT leadership meeting in nine and a half years:** The April 10 Beijing meeting was framed around the 1992 Consensus and peaceful unification, projecting conciliation toward KMT while isolating Taiwan's ruling DPP.

**Bloomberg: "Taiwan Plans Drills to Break Potential Chinese Energy Blockade"**, 2026-04-13, <https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2026-04-12/taiwan-plans-drills-to-break-potential-chinese-energy-blockade>

- **Taiwan's Interior Ministry to lead first-ever blockade escort drills:** Joint exercises before July will simulate naval escort of oil and gas shipments through three maritime corridors toward the Philippines, Japan, and the US.
- **Deputy interior minister warned a Taiwan blockade would disrupt regional energy supply:** Mars cited Iran's Hormuz closure as a direct analogue and said Taiwan expects partner countries including Japan to assist future escort missions.
- **PLA's "Justice Mission 2025" deployed 89 aircraft and 28 vessels in December:** The encirclement drill covered a wider area than any exercise since the 2022 Pelosi-triggered operation, according to the article.

**Foreign Affairs: "Europe Still Needs China"**, 2026-04-17, <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/china/europe-still-needs-china>

- **Tsinghua professor argues US-Europe contradiction now rivals China-Europe tensions:** The author contends that Trump administration nationalism threatens the

foundations of European integration more acutely than any China-Europe trade or policy dispute.

- **July 2025 EU-China summit yielded only a boilerplate climate statement:** According to the article, both Chinese and European analysts interpreted the Costa-von der Leyen Beijing visit as signalling a risk of further relational decline.
- **China views Europe as a desired multipolar pole but finds it perplexing to deal with:** Beijing wants Europe to offset US pressure, the author reports, but perceives European strategic autonomy rhetoric as applied selectively against China rather than Washington.

**Reuters: “Spain, China pledge closer ties in the face of threats to world order”, 2026-04-14,** <https://www.reuters.com/world/china/spanish-premier-chinas-xi-pledge-closer-ties-amid-crumbling-international-order-2026-04-14>

- **Sanchez and Xi met in Beijing, pledging closer bilateral ties:** Xi described the international order as “crumbling” and said deeper China-Spain ties served both countries’ interests, according to Reuters.
- **Beijing agreed to measures to narrow Spain’s nearly \$50 billion trade deficit:** Sanchez said he would sign agreements with Premier Li Qiang on Spanish agricultural market access and transport infrastructure.

**Bloomberg: “China Steps Up Outreach to Italy During Trump’s Rift With Meloni”, 2026-04-17,** <https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2026-04-17/china-steps-up-outreach-to-italy-during-trump-s-rift-with-meloni>

- **Wang Yi called for deepened Italy-China strategic dialogue:** The Chinese foreign minister urged continued high-level contacts and stronger coordination in international affairs, according to a Chinese Foreign Ministry readout.
- **Italian FM Tajani announced a new Venice-Beijing air route opening in July:** Tajani also asked Beijing to support efforts to end the wars in Ukraine and the Middle East, and met China’s commerce minister during the visit.

**Nikkei: “New Hungary PM seen resetting rules for China, EV sector: 4 things to know”, 2026-04-14,** <https://asia.nikkei.com/politics/international-relations/new-hungary-pm-seen-resetting-rules-for-china-ev-sector-4-things-to-know>

- **Hungarian opposition leader Magyar won elections, ousting Orban after 16 years:** Magyar’s Tisza party won with a record 77.8% voter turnout, and he is set to take office on 12 May.
- **China loses its most reliable EU veto-holder:** Analysts cited by Nikkei expect Magyar to align with EU policy norms, reducing China’s capacity to block common EU positions, though Spain’s Sanchez and Germany’s Merz are identified as potential alternative interlocutors.
- **Chinese and South Korean EV and battery investors face stricter operating conditions:** New environmental compliance rules, reduced subsidies, and higher energy costs are expected, though analysts say Hungary’s EU market access will sustain investor interest.



**Caixin: “China Slams UK Decision to Block Ming Yang Wind Turbines”**, 2026-04-15, <https://www.caixinglobal.com/2026-04-14/china-slams-uk-decision-to-block-ming-yang-wind-turbines-102434083.html>

- **China’s commerce ministry condemned the UK’s Ming Yang turbine ban:** A ministry spokesperson said the exclusion of Chinese products contradicts the UK’s open-market principles and risks damaging bilateral trade relations.
- **UK Energy Minister confirmed the ban on 26 March, citing national security:** The government will not support Ming Yang turbines in offshore wind projects, which are central to the UK’s target of expanding offshore capacity from 15GW to 43-50GW by 2030.

**Caixin: “China to Scrap Import Tariffs for 53 African Nations on May 1”**, 2026-04-13, <https://www.caixinglobal.com/2026-04-13/china-to-scrap-import-tariffs-for-53-african-nations-on-may-1-102433425.html>

- **China to scrap all import tariffs for 53 African nations from May 1:** The measure expands a December 2024 zero-tariff policy covering 33 least developed countries to all African states with which Beijing maintains diplomatic relations.
- **Bilateral trade reached \$314.4 billion in the first 11 months of 2025:** According to Caixin, this represented a 17.8% year-on-year increase, coinciding with the 70th anniversary of China-Africa ties.

**SCMP: “US will help Peru ‘take back’ Chancay port from China, Congress chair says”**, 2026-04-17, <https://www.scmp.com/news/china/article/3350379/us-will-help-peru-take-back-chancay-port-china-congress-chair-says>

- **US lawmaker called on Peru’s next government to reclaim Chancay port:** Congresswoman Maria Elvira Salazar, chair of the House Foreign Affairs Subcommittee on the Western Hemisphere, said Washington would help Peru remove Chinese operator Cosco from the facility.
- **Peruvian court freed Cosco from national regulatory oversight in February:** A Lima court ruled in Cosco’s favour after the company argued the terminal was built with private capital and not under a state concession contract.

**FT: “China told Maersk and MSC to drop Panama port operations”**, 2026-04-15, <https://www.ft.com/content/91d60b9e-374d-4dc3-bd57-3cfb3221f400>

- **NDRC summoned Maersk and MSC, demanding immediate Panama port withdrawal:** China’s state planner met both European shipping groups last month and ordered them to cease operations at the Balboa and Cristóbal terminals, according to three people familiar with the talks.
- **Maersk CEO and MSC president engaged NDRC directly as companies resisted:** Vincent Clerc attended a Beijing meeting on March 20 and Diego Aponte communicated by correspondence, with both firms arguing temporary concessions are necessary to maintain canal trade flows.
- **Beijing’s demands follow Panama stripping CK Hutchison of port rights:** Panama’s supreme court ruled the original concession unconstitutional in January; MSC and Maersk were subsequently granted temporary operating rights, prompting CK Hutchison to file a \$2 billion damages claim against Panama.

**SCMP: “Brazil fires slave labour watchdog chief after BYD blacklisting”**, 2026-04-14, <https://www.scmp.com/news/china/diplomacy/article/3349965/brazil-fires-slave-labour-watchdog-chief-after-byd-blacklisting>

- **Brazil dismissed its chief labour inspector days after BYD was blacklisted:** The official led the National Secretariat of Labour Inspection since 2023; his removal was published in the official gazette on Monday.
- **Labour inspectors’ union filed a Supreme Court challenge over ministerial interference:** Anafitra accused Labour Minister Luiz Marinho of shielding large companies from completed slave labour enforcement proceedings, calling the dismissal institutional retaliation.

**NYT: “Xi Courts Vietnam With His Authoritarian Vision of Security”**, 2026-04-16, <https://www.nytimes.com/2026/04/16/world/asia/xi-china-vietnam-security.html>

- **Xi invoked Trump tariffs and Hormuz disruptions to pitch closer Vietnam ties:** Xi cited shared supply chain vulnerabilities and Communist Party kinship as grounds for deepening political and security coordination with Hanoi.
- **China-Vietnam security cooperation involves seniority and density unmatched by the US:** A political scientist cited by the NYT noted China’s Public Security Ministry holds more cooperation agreements with Vietnam than any other country, with spy chief participation publicly acknowledged.
- **Vietnam’s To Lam consolidated power and chose Beijing for his first foreign trip:** His elevation - combining party general secretary and presidency - and expanded police powers move Vietnam toward a governance model closer to China’s, the article reports.

**Carnegie: “China-Vietnam Security Cooperation Glimpse of Future Chinese Diplomacy with Southeast Asia”**, 2026-04-13, <https://carnegieendowment.org/research/2026/04/china-vietnam-engagements-offer-a-glimpse-of-future-chinese-diplomacy-with-southeast-asia>

- **China elevated its Vietnam security dialogue to ministerial level in March 2026:** The “3+3” format - pairing foreign, defence, and public security ministers - concluded with three new bilateral security agreements.
- **Public Security Minister Wang Xiaohong prioritised political security and countering colour revolutions:** The ninth ministerial crime-control conference produced commitments on cybersecurity, telecom fraud, drug control, and police capacity-building through technology-sharing.
- **The author argues the Vietnam model could be replicated across Southeast Asia:** Beijing may extend the “3+3” mechanism to Laos, Myanmar, Thailand, and Cambodia, using the LMLECC and China-ASEAN forums as multilateral platforms.

**Reuters: “China model gains appeal in Vietnam as police expand power”**, 2026-04-13, <https://www.reuters.com/world/china/china-model-gains-appeal-vietnam-police-expand-power-2026-04-13>

- **Vietnam adopting Chinese-style data controls and surveillance infrastructure:** Draft documents seen by Reuters show Hanoi plans state-run data exchanges overseen by the public security ministry, mirroring China’s centralised model.

- **To Lam's Beijing visit expected to yield dozens of cooperation agreements:** Vietnam has dropped 5G concerns and Chinese investment in manufacturing and data centres is rising, according to Reuters sources.
- **Hanoi considering a China-modelled stock market stabilisation fund:** An internal security ministry document reviewed by Reuters explicitly cites China's fund as the template for proposed equity market intervention.

**Lowy Institute: "Marcos Overture to China Masks Anxiety About US Reliability"**, 2026-04-14, <https://www.lowyinstitute.org/the-interpreter/marcos-s-overture-china-masks-anxiety-about-us-reliability>

- **Marcos's China outreach framed as frustration with US Middle East policy:** The author argues the Bloomberg interview signals discontent with America's Iran war rather than a substantive shift toward Beijing on South China Sea energy deals.
- **US missile defence relocations to the Middle East raised alarm among Asian allies:** South Korea, Japan, Taiwan, and the Philippines are reassessing defence reliance on Washington following Iran's saturation drone-and-missile strategy against US bases in the Gulf, according to the article.
- **Asian allies expected to pursue minilateral defence cooperation over US dependence:** The article reports the Philippines is hosting its largest-ever Balikatan exercises this year, with Japanese Self-Defence Forces participating in combat-related drills for the first time.

**Reuters: "Philippines says any energy deals with China must respect its sovereignty"**, 2026-04-13, <https://www.reuters.com/business/energy/philippines-says-any-energy-deals-with-china-must-respect-its-sovereignty-2026-04-12>

- **Manila sets sovereignty conditions for South China Sea energy talks:** The Philippine Department of Foreign Affairs stated any oil and gas cooperation agreement with China must comply fully with the Philippine constitution and national law.
- **Philippines and China resumed preliminary energy talks in late March:** Discussions cover initial steps toward South China Sea oil and gas cooperation, as well as energy and fertiliser supply disruptions linked to the Middle East conflict.

## 5. Strategic implications and responses

**Foreign Affairs: "The Tech High Ground"**, 2026-04-15, <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/united-states/tech-high-ground-jake-sullivan>

- **Sullivan argues the US-China tech race has no finish line:** The author contends Washington must pursue simultaneous advantages in innovation, production, and supply chain control rather than treating breakthroughs as self-sustaining leads.
- **Sullivan calls for Operation Warp Speed-style mobilisation across frontier industries:** The piece recommends deploying public investment, price floors, and long-term purchase contracts to spur domestic production of advanced batteries, drones, and robotics.
- **"Small yard, high fence" framed as the correct export control doctrine:** Sullivan defends the Biden-era chip controls and argues that China had already prioritised domestic semiconductor development before those restrictions were introduced.

**CSIS: “Closing the Local Knowledge Gap in U.S. Competition with China”,** 2026-04-16, <https://www.csis.org/analysis/closing-local-knowledge-gap-us-competition-china>

- **CSIS argues the US lacks local knowledge to counter Chinese influence:** The authors contend Washington must integrate private-sector data tools and AI to match China’s hyper-local engagement strategy.
- **China’s local engagement combines BRI infrastructure, media, and security ties:** Case studies in Cambodia and Tajikistan show positive local perceptions of China outpacing those of the US by wide margins.
- **Recent US foreign aid cuts create openings for Chinese engagement:** Within one week of the US cancelling Cambodia literacy and nutrition programmes, China’s aid agency announced equivalent funding, according to the article.

**Foreign Affairs: “The Iran War Is a Win for China”,** 2026-04-17, <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/united-states/iran-war-win-china>

- **Authors argue the Iran war hands China strategic advantages ahead of the Trump-Xi summit:** According to the piece, U.S. military commitments in the Middle East have depleted Indo-Pacific assets and weakened deterrence against both North Korea and China.
- **China’s energy resilience limits its exposure to Strait of Hormuz disruption:** The article reports China holds an estimated 1.4 billion barrels in strategic reserves, covering over six months of total strait disruption, with Russian oil as a further fallback.
- **Authors warn Xi may offer Boeing orders to extract U.S. technology export concessions:** According to the piece, such a deal - potentially covering AI chips and jet turbines - would accelerate China’s technological self-sufficiency at the expense of long-term U.S. competitive advantage.

**Bloomberg: “Americans’ Views of China Improve Ahead of Trump-Xi Summit”,** 2026-04-15, <https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2026-04-15/americans-views-of-china-improve-ahead-of-trump-xi-summit>

- **Pew survey records a near-doubling of favourable US views of China:** 27% of Americans held a favourable view of China in March 2026, up from a record low in 2023 following the spy balloon incident.
- **Democratic approval rose eight points; Republican views were unchanged:** Confidence in Xi to “do the right thing” gained four percentage points, while confidence in Trump on China policy fell six points.

**SCMP: “To compete with China, US needs to rebuild rare earth talent from the ground up”,** 2026-04-14, <https://www.scmp.com/news/china/diplomacy/article/3349894/compete-china-us-needs-rebuild-rare-earth-talent-ground>

- **US rare earth ambitions hinge on talent, not just resources:** Experts say eroding industrial know-how and a weak education pipeline are the decisive obstacles to rebuilding a domestic supply chain.
- **Rare earths expected to feature in May Trump-Xi summit:** The meeting, postponed from March due to the Iran conflict, is reported by SCMP to be partly driven by the rare earth supply dispute.

**FT: “China shock 2.0: should Europe repel Chinese investment?”**, 2026-04-15,  
<https://www.ft.com/content/873ac1ea-8924-4600-b67d-0c078b917b55>

- **EU’s Industrial Accelerator Act attaches conditions to Chinese FDI over €100mn:** Member states may veto investments in strategic sectors if the investor’s home country holds over 40% of global manufacturing capacity in that sector.
- **Chinese greenfield investment in Europe nearly tripled to \$12bn in 2024:** Rhodium Group data show the bulk went to Hungary, with batteries, EVs, and clean energy as the primary destination sectors.
- **Spain actively courts Chinese manufacturers to offset deindustrialisation:** Hithium announced a €400mn battery factory in Navarra in March, with the idle former Bosch site among shortlisted locations.

**Caixin: “EU Shuts China Out of Science Projects, but Europe Will Pay the Price”**, 2026-04-14, <https://www.caixinglobal.com/2026-04-14/commentary-eu-shuts-china-out-of-science-projects-but-europe-will-pay-the-price-102433970.html>

- **EU announced exclusion of Chinese institutions from Horizon Europe core areas:** From 2026, Chinese entities are barred from AI, quantum, semiconductors, and biotechnology under the 95.5 billion euro programme, according to the article.
- **The author argues the exclusion harms Europe more than China:** EU corporate R&D stands at 1.2% of GDP versus China’s 2.6%, and the EU holds only 109 of 1,453 global unicorns, weakening its position to absorb frontier technology independently.
- **China urged to respond by recruiting suspended EU researchers:** The article recommends attracting European talent in quantum, AI, and biotech by offering manufacturing access and commercialisation infrastructure that Europe currently lacks.

**Nikkei: “Italy imposes curbs on China’s Sinochem to avoid US restrictions on Pirelli”**, 2026-04-13, <https://asia.nikkei.com/politics/italy-imposes-curbs-on-china-s-sinochem-to-avoid-us-restrictions-on-pirelli>

- **Italy invoked golden power rules to restrict Sinochem’s role in Pirelli:** Rome capped Sinochem’s board nominees at three and barred its members from holding top executive offices, according to Pirelli’s statement.
- **Curbs target Sinochem’s 34% stake amid US market access concerns:** Both Pirelli and Camfin cited Washington’s tightening restrictions on Chinese automotive technology as grounds for limiting the Chinese shareholder’s influence.

**NYT: “Aiming at China, Malaysia Puts New Restrictions on Electric Cars”**, 2026-04-13, <https://www.nytimes.com/2026/04/13/world/asia/malaysia-electric-cars-china.html>

- **Malaysia doubled the minimum import price for electric vehicles to 200,000 ringgit:** The measure, announced by trade minister Johari Abdul Ghani, targets Chinese-made EVs that came to dominate the market after a tax holiday ended in December 2025.
- **BYD and Chery face a 20% domestic sales cap if they build local assembly plants:** Chery has begun construction near Kuala Lumpur, while BYD says it is “still reviewing all possibilities.”

**Nikkei: “Opinion: China’s more-than-decade-late sanctions ineffective as leverage on Japan”, 2026-04-15, <https://asia.nikkei.com/opinion/china-s-more-than-decade-late-sanctions-ineffective-as-leverage-on-japan>**

- **China’s February blacklist of 20 Japanese firms arrived after key supply chain decisions:** The author argues sanctions targeting Mitsubishi Heavy and others cannot reverse a decade of Japanese diversification away from Chinese rare earths.
- **Japan’s rare earth dependence on China fell from 85% in 2009 to 58% by 2020:** State-backed diversification into Australia, Vietnam, and Africa, plus recycling investment, preceded Beijing’s 2026 controls, according to the article.
- **Personal sanctions on LDP lawmaker Furuya reinforce rather than deter Tokyo’s Taiwan engagement:** The author argues the measures hand Japanese officials a domestic narrative of Chinese intimidation, strengthening the case for deeper alliance coordination.

**NYT: “Mutually Automated Destruction: The Escalating Global A.I. Arms Race”, 2026-04-13, <https://www.nytimes.com/2026/04/12/technology/china-russia-us-ai-weapons.html>**

- **Pentagon concluded US autonomous drone programme lagged China’s after Beijing’s September parade:** Following China’s display of fighter jet-accompanying autonomous drones, Anduril began manufacturing comparable systems three months ahead of schedule.
- **China leads in autonomous weapons production scale; US responds with AI-driven targeting at pace:** Maven, embedded with Anthropic’s Claude, generated thousands of Iran strike targets in weeks, while China replicates equivalent targeting architectures, according to Georgetown researchers.
- **RAND exercises found autonomous systems caused inadvertent escalation in US-Japan missile scenarios:** Researchers warn that AI weapons’ speed outpaces human decision-making, risking escalatory spirals from untested systems.

**Brookings: “Competing AI Strategies for the US and China”, 2026-04-16, <https://www.brookings.edu/articles/competing-ai-strategies-for-the-us-and-china>**

- **US House testimony documents China’s three-track AI strategy:** The author argues China is prioritising model efficiency, open-source adoption, and physical AI integration rather than competing directly for AGI supremacy.
- **Chinese domestic AI chips reached 41% market share in 2025:** This compares to over 90% for Nvidia before 2023, according to IDC data cited in the testimony.
- **Author recommends US shift emphasis from export controls to infrastructure:** The testimony argues controls slow China short-term but may accelerate its semiconductor self-sufficiency over the medium and long term.

**SCMP: “China willing to ‘buy’ or ‘steal’ US tech to get ahead in AI race, Congress told”, 2026-04-17, <https://www.scmp.com/news/china/diplomacy/article/3350380/china-willing-buy-or-steal-us-tech-get-ahead-ai-race-congress-told>**

- **House Select Committee accused China of acquiring US chips illegally:** Chairman Moolenaar alleged Chinese AI firms use legal and illegal means to circumvent export controls on high-end semiconductors.



- **Witnesses identified compute power as the decisive variable in the AI race:** Silverado Policy Accelerator chairman Dmitri Alperovitch called compute “the single most important input to winning” over China.

**Bloomberg: “Bessent Calls Anthropic’s Mythos a Breakthrough in China AI Race”**, 2026-04-15, <https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2026-04-15/bessent-calls-anthropic-s-mythos-a-breakthrough-in-china-ai-race>

- **Bessent publicly endorsed Anthropic’s Mythos as a decisive US lead over China:** The Treasury Secretary said the US holds a three-to-six month AI advantage, describing Mythos as a “step function change” in capability.
- **Anthropic faces domestic US legal disputes despite Bessent’s endorsement:** The Pentagon designated the company a supply chain threat this year, and Anthropic secured a court order last month blocking a resulting ban on government use of its technology.

**Reuters: “U.S. lawmakers scale back bill targeting Chinese chipmaking”**, 2026-04-17, <https://www.reuters.com/world/china/us-lawmakers-scale-back-bill-targeting-chinese-chipmaking-2026-04-16>

- **MATCH Act revised to narrow scope before committee vote:** Many earlier countrywide curbs were removed, including restrictions on cryogenic etch tools made by Lam Research and Tokyo Electron, according to Reuters.
- **Revised bill retains new DUV immersion lithography restriction on ASML:** It also bars foreign firms from selling to CXMT, YMTC, and SMIC at facilities already blocked from using American equipment.

**Wired: “6,000 Meters Under the Pacific, Japan Seeks Independence From China on Rare Earths”**, 2026-04-17, <https://www.wired.com/story/under-the-pacific-japan-seeks-independence-from-china-on-rare-earths>

- **Japan and the US signed a rare earths cooperation pact covering Minamitorishima:** The Tokyo Framework, agreed during Trump’s visit to Japan in October, includes joint investment, bilateral coordination mechanisms, and US funding for extraction operations planned for 2026.
- **Japan has halved its rare earth dependence on China since 2010:** Through supplier diversification, strategic stockpiling, recycling, and investment in reduced-use magnet technology, China’s share of Japan’s rare earth imports fell from over 90% to approximately 50%.
- **Minamitorishima seabed samples suggest reserves of over 16 million tons of rare earths:** Japanese researchers recovered sediment from depths of up to 6,000 metres - the world’s first such attempt - with estimated deposits covering 730 and 780 years of dysprosium and yttrium consumption respectively.

**WSJ: “Ford Will Partner More With Chinese Automakers Overseas”**, 2026-04-17, <https://www.wsj.com/business/autos/ford-will-partner-more-with-chinese-automakers-overseas-66cc23c9>

- **Ford CEO publicly acknowledged Chinese auto leadership and signalled future partnerships:** Jim Farley said Chinese manufacturers lead in technology, cost, and speed, and confirmed Ford will expand overseas partnerships with Chinese firms.

- **Farley conditionally opened the door to Chinese vehicles entering the US market:** He argued a domestic protection plan must precede any Chinese imports or local production, citing factory and job losses in countries that moved too quickly.

### III. WOCHENBERICHT: CN-BEZIEHUNGEN DURCH DIE DE-MEDIEN-BRILLE

*Caveat: nur stichprobenartig auf Qualität/Richtigkeit überprüft – Coverage nur bis 17.4.*

#### 1. Prominente Zitate und Positionen zu China-bezogenen Angelegenheiten

- **Donald Trump** beteuerte am Mittwoch gegenüber dem Fernsehsender Fox Business seine Gelassenheit bezüglich Pekings Energieversorgung in der Hormus-Krise und sagte: „Xi braucht Öl, wir nicht.“ (Source: „Hortet China Öl?“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 16. April 2026).
- **Li Qiang** (Chinesischer Ministerpräsident) forderte laut Bericht vom Donnerstag in Peking eine Kurskorrektur im Welthandel, da man gemeinsam daran arbeiten müsse, den Austausch „ausgewogener“ zu gestalten, um die wachsende Ungeduld in Europa zu adressieren. (Source: „Konjunktur; Chinas Wirtschaft trotz dem Iran-Krieg – noch“, wiwo.de, 16. April 2026).
- **Ursula von der Leyen** präsentierte am Freitag einen Plan zur Abschaffung des Einstimmigkeitsprinzips in der Außenpolitik und erklärte, man müsse die EU „fit für eine Welt“ machen, in der Demokratien immer stärker unter Druck geraten. (Source: „„Historische“ Chance auf EU-Reformen nach Orbáns Abwahl“, Der Tagesspiegel, 17. April 2026).
- **Pedro Sánchez** (Spanischer Ministerpräsident) mahnte am Dienstag in Peking eine stärkere Öffnung des chinesischen Marktes an und betonte: „China muss es uns leicht tun. Es muss sich öffnen, damit Europa sich nicht abschotten muss.“ (Source: „SPANISCHER REGIERUNGSCHEF; Darum rollt man Sánchez in Peking den roten Teppich aus“, faz.net, 14. April 2026).
- **Yvette Cooper** (Britische Außenministerin) stellte am Donnerstag in Berlin klar: „Es kann definitiv nicht sein, dass Seewege wie die Straße von Hormus von einzelnen Staaten kontrolliert werden und dass dort Zölle erhoben werden.“ (Source: „Internationale Initiative für freien Schiffsverkehr in Meerenge“, handelsblatt.com, 17. April 2026).
- **Michael Kretschmer** (Ministerpräsident Sachsens, CDU) warnte am Mittwoch in der ARD-Talkshow „Maischberger“ vor den globalen Machtverschiebungen: „Wir befinden uns in einem großen Wirtschaftskrieg, mit China und mit Russland.“ (Source: „Sachsen-Chef Kretschmer warnt; Deutschland steckt im „Tal des Todes““, bild.de, 15. April 2026).
- **Markus Söder** erklärte am Montag nach einer Kabinettsitzung in Berlin, dass Deutschland die strategischen Fehler der Vergangenheit nicht wiederholen dürfe: „Wir dürfen China nicht einfach den wichtigen Markt [der Verbrenner] schenken.“ (Source: „So verteidigt Berlin den Verbrenner“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 14. April 2026).
- **Indermit Gill** (Chefökonom der Weltbank) mahnte am Donnerstag in einem Interview, dass der zunehmende Protektionismus der Industriestaaten den globalen Fortschritt gefährde: „Die großen Volkswirtschaften verzerren den Handel seit fünfzehn Jahren“

in einem beispiellosen Ausmaß.“ (Source: „WELTBANK-CHEFÖKONOM IM INTERVIEW“, faz.net, 16. April 2026).

- **Christophe Fouquet** (Vorstandsvorsitzender ASML) prognostizierte am Mittwoch angesichts der globalen Nachfrage nach KI-Hardware ein Rekordjahr für den Konzern: „Die Nachfrage nach Chips übersteigt das Angebot.“ (Source: „ASML begehrt wie nie“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 16. April 2026).
- **Ralf Brandstätter** (VW-China-Vorstand) beschrieb am Donnerstag die existenzielle Härte auf dem asiatischen Automarkt: „Dieser Wettbewerb ist extrem. Mehr als 100 Marken versuchen sich hier ihren Teil am Kuchen zu sichern.“ (Source: „Der Wettbewerb in China ist extrem“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 16. April 2026).
- **Stefan Hartung** (Bosch-Chef) warnte am Donnerstag bei der Bilanzpressekonferenz seines Unternehmens: „In der Automobilbranche setze China derzeit die Standards beim Preisniveau.“ (Source: „Autozulieferer; Bosch überrascht nach roten Zahlen mit positivem Ausblick“, handelsblatt.com, 16. April 2026).
- **Arnd Franz** (Vorstandschef Mahle) forderte am Mittwoch eine Beschleunigung der europäischen Industrie und konstatierte: „Die Industrie in Europa ist zu langsam [...] In Fernost agiere Mahle im „China-Speed“.“ (Source: „Autozulieferer; Mahle droht wegen des Verbrennerverbots mit Werksschließungen“, handelsblatt.com, 15. April 2026).
- **Ola Källenius** (Vorstandschef Mercedes-Benz) bezeichnete den Wettbewerb in der Volksrepublik am Donnerstag auf der Hauptversammlung als ultimative Belastungsprobe: „China ist für die Autoindustrie so etwas wie das härteste Rennen der Welt.“ (Source: „Autobauer; „Alarmsignal“ – Aktionäre sorgen sich um Mercedes“, handelsblatt.com, 16. April 2026).
- **Andreas Pecher** (Vorstandsvorsitzender Zeiss) betonte am Dienstag die gewachsene Bedeutung politischer Flankierung für deutsche Technologieführer: „Ich weiß nicht, ob ich vor zehn oder fünfzehn Jahren eine Reise mit dem Bundeskanzler nach China unternommen hätte. Jetzt lohnt sich das.“ (Source: „ANDREAS PECHER; „Durch den Krieg werden Investitionen zurückgehalten“, Handelsblatt, 14. April 2026).
- **Eva Riesenhuber** (Nachhaltigkeitschefin Siemens) hob am Freitag in München hervor: „Basierend auf einer langfristigen Planung sei China führend in der Dekarbonisierung und in der Kreislaufwirtschaft.“ (Source: „Trotz Trump: Für Siemens rechnet sich Nachhaltigkeit“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 17. April 2026).
- **Ralf Wintergerst** (Bitkom-Präsident) kritisierte am Donnerstag die Trägheit deutscher Entscheidungsprozesse gegenüber dem Systemrivalen: „Das von der Kommunistischen Partei regierte China kann [...] politische Entscheidungen sehr rasch umsetzen. [...] Deutschland ist politisch im Kern nicht handlungsfähig.“ (Source: „Deutschland ist politisch nicht handlungsfähig“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 17. April 2026).
- **Hendrik Brandis** (Partner Earlybird Venture Capital) beklagte am Dienstag die mangelnde Ambition im europäischen Tech-Sektor: „Europa denkt zu klein. Im globalen Tech-Wettlauf ist nicht nur zu wenig Kapital das Problem, sondern auch Überregulierung.“ (Source: „HANDELSBLATT — GASTKOMMENTAR —; Europa denkt zu klein“, Handelsblatt, 14. April 2026).

- **Andrew Small** (Direktor Asienprogramm ECFR) analysierte am Donnerstag wie Peking die globale Krise instrumentalisiert: „Peking wird Einfluss und Dominanz über die globalen Lieferketten weiter ausbauen [...] China – Profiteur im Schatten des Irankriegs.“ (Source: „HANDELSBLATT — GASTKOMMENTAR —; China – Profiteur im Schatten des Irankriegs“, Handelsblatt, 16. April 2026).
- **Jens Eskelund** (Präsident der EU-Handelskammer China) warnte am Dienstag in Peking vor den Folgen einer Entkopplung: „Ich glaube nicht, dass irgendjemand wirklich weiß, ob Europa ohne China überhaupt Zahnpasta herstellen könnte.“ (Source: „Rohstoffabhängigkeit; „Ich glaube nicht, dass irgendjemand wirklich weiß“, Spiegel Online, 14. April 2026).
- **Christian Dustmann** (Professor, UC London) konstatierte am Mittwoch den relativen Bedeutungsverlust der deutschen Wirtschaft: „Aktuell hat die deutsche Industrie dem Weltmarkt weniger anzubieten. China nimmt den Deutschen die Kunden weg.“ (Source: „Reform des Arbeitsmarkts; Eine Agenda 2030? Hilft doch auch nicht“, zeit.de, 15. April 2026).
- **Achim Truger** (Wirtschaftsweiser) analysierte am Mittwoch die Ursachen der konjunkturellen Schwäche in Deutschland: „Im Wesentlichen entsteht der Abschwung aus den zurückgehenden Exporten. Ich habe den Eindruck, die Debatte ist diagnosefrei.“ (Source: „Reform des Arbeitsmarkts; Eine Agenda 2030? Hilft doch auch nicht“, zeit.de, 15. April 2026).
- **Lutz Niedermark** (Hauptgeschäftsführer BDI) betonte am Mittwoch die Notwendigkeit einer aktiven Handelspolitik: „Handelsabkommen sind kein außenpolitisches Randthema, sondern ein zentraler industriepolitischer Hebel.“ (Source: „KONJUNKTUR; Industrie muss neue Märkte suchen“, Handelsblatt, 15. April 2026).
- **Zichun Huang** (Ökonom, Capital Economics) prognostizierte am Dienstag eine günstige Entwicklung für Peking: „China dürfte durch die hohe Nachfrage nach Halbleitern und grünen Technologien [durch den Irankrieg] profitieren.“ (Source: „Wirtschaft in China; Chinas Exportwachstum lässt im März deutlich nach“, zeit.de, 14. April 2026).
- **Andreas Nebeling** (Manager, Elmos Semiconductor) warnte am Donnerstag vor neuen technologischen Bedrohungen: „Verschlüsselte Datenkommunikation basiert auf Zufallszahlen. [...] Durch den Einsatz von KI und Quantencomputern können Angreifer ihre Methoden [...] deutlich schneller weiterentwickeln.“ (Source: „Diese Unternehmen machen mit ihren Ideen Mut für die Zukunft“, wiwo.de, 16. April 2026).
- **Lennart Pfahler** (Journalist) berichtete am Freitag über die Entdeckung geheimer chinesischer Lieferrouten für militärische Güter: „Die Spur beginnt an der Front in Kherson und führt über Shanghai [...] Komponenten sind offenbar an einen russischen Drohnenhersteller geliefert worden.“ (Source: „Der Schröder-Bekannte und die verborgene Route der Drohnenteile“, Die Welt, 17. April 2026).

## 2. Wichtige China-bezogene Entwicklungen in Fakten und Zahlen

- **Starkes Wirtschaftswachstum in China im 1. Quartal 2026:** Das BIP der Volksrepublik wuchs im Vergleich zum Vorjahreszeitraum um 5,0 Prozent und lag damit über den Analystenerwartungen von 4,8 Prozent. (Source: „BIP; Chinas Wirtschaft wächst stärker als erwartet – trotz Iran-Krieg“, handelsblatt.com, 16. April 2026).

- **Absatzeinbruch deutscher Autobauer in China:** BMW meldete für das erste Quartal 2026 ein Absatzminus in China von 10 Prozent; bei Mercedes-Benz brach der Absatz in der Volksrepublik im gleichen Zeitraum sogar um 27 Prozent ein. (Source: „BMW verkauft weniger Autos“, BILD Stuttgart, 15. April 2026; „Autobauer; „Alarmsignal“ – Aktionäre sorgen sich um Mercedes“, handelsblatt.com, 16. April 2026).
- **Dominanz Chinas bei Patenten für digitale Schlüsseltechnologien:** Im Jahr 2025 wurden über 10.000 Digital-Patentanmeldungen aus China veröffentlicht, womit das Land weltweit auf Rang zwei hinter den USA (>15.000) liegt, während Deutschland erst langsam aufholt. (Source: „Schlüsseltechnologien; Patentamt: Deutschland holt in Digitaltechnik auf“, wiwo.de, 16. April 2026).
- **Ausweitung der EU-Stahlzölle:** Die Europäische Union hat sich vorläufig darauf geeinigt, die Stahlimporte nahezu zu halbieren und Zölle von 50 Prozent auf überschüssige Lieferungen aus Drittstaaten wie China zu erheben. (Source: „EU einigt sich auf Kürzung der Stahlimporte“, Der Tagesspiegel, 15. April 2026).
- **Einbruch des chinesischen Exportwachstums im März:** Die chinesischen Ausfuhren stiegen im März 2026 nur noch um 2,5 Prozent (erheblich schwächer als in den Vormonaten), was primär auf die Verwerfungen durch den Iran-Krieg zurückgeführt wird. (Source: „Teure Energie und Nahost-Krieg belasten Chinas Exporte“, Der Tagesspiegel, 15. April 2026).
- **Fortführung der Hormus-Blockade:** Trotz Waffenruhe passieren derzeit nur noch durchschnittlich 6 Schiffe pro Tag die Straße von Hormus (zuvor 9), was die globale Logistik dauerhaft belastet. (Source: „Börsen erklären den Irankrieg für beendet – zu Recht?“, handelsblatt.com, 16. April 2026).
- **Historischer Boom bei Elektroauto-Neuzulassungen in Deutschland:** Im März 2026 stiegen die Neuzulassungen reiner E-Autos in Deutschland um 66 Prozent, maßgeblich getrieben durch staatliche Förderprogramme und Rabattaktionen. (Source: „ELEKTROMOBILITÄT; Teslas spektakuläre Rückkehr“, faz.net, 15. April 2026).
- **Kluft bei Forscher-Investitionen:** Laut OECD-Daten investiert China pro Forscher durchschnittlich 323.000 Dollar, während der entsprechende Vergleichswert in der Europäischen Union lediglich bei 280.000 Dollar liegt. (Source: „Achtmal China in den Top Ten“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 15. April 2026).
- **Rekord-Absolventenzahlen:** Im Zeitraum von 2021 bis 2025 brachte China insgesamt 55 Millionen Universitätsabsolventen hervor, was die personelle Basis für den technologischen Skalierungsvorteil des Landes zementiert. (Source: „Achtmal China in den Top Ten“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 15. April 2026).
- **Lokalisierung der Methan-Quellen:** Satellitenauswertungen der Harvard University belegen, dass Methan-Emissionen in Europa primär auf Nutztierhaltung und Müll zurückzuführen sind, während in China Kohleminen dominieren. (Source: „Aus Stall, Deponie und Kohlemine“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 15. April 2026).
- **TSMC Gewinn-Explosion:** Der taiwanische Chiphersteller TSMC steigerte sein Nettoergebnis im ersten Quartal 2026 überraschend deutlich um 58 % auf 15,37 Milliarden Euro. (Source: „Chips; TSMC erwartet dank KI-Boom Fortsetzung der Rekordjagd“, handelsblatt.com, 16. April 2026).

- **Sicherung des China-Automarktes:** Experten prognostizieren für 2026 ein Marktniveau von nur noch 24 Millionen Fahrzeugen in China, wobei der Anteil elektrifizierter Neuzulassungen auf 60 % steigen soll. (Source: „VOLKSWAGEN-CHINA-VORSTAND; „Der Wettbewerb ist extrem“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 16. April 2026).
- **Preisschock an chinesischen Zapfsäulen:** Infolge der Hormus-Blockade hat Peking den Benzinpreis fünfmal angehoben, womit er um 20 % auf 8,34 Yuan (ca. 1 Euro) pro Liter stieg. (Source: „Plötzlich doppelt verwundbar“, Süddeutsche Zeitung, 16. April 2026).
- **China-Satelliten-Dichte:** China baute 2025 seine Orbit-Infrastruktur mit 93 Raketenstarts massiv aus, wobei erstmals 16 Starts durch private chinesische Firmen durchgeführt wurden. (Source: „Der Preis des Himmels“, DIE ZEIT, 16. April 2026).

### 3. Fünf zentrale Themen in der deutschen China-Politik Diskussion

- **Die Krise der politischen Handlungsfähigkeit und der Ruf nach dem „Pakt für Deutschland“:** In der deutschen Wirtschafts- und Digitalpolitik herrscht Alarmstimmung angesichts der Lähmung durch bürokratische Blockaden. Während China strategische Ziele in Schlüsseltechnologien wie Robotik und KI mit beispielloser Geschwindigkeit umsetzt, sieht Bitkom-Präsident Wintergerst Deutschland als „politisch nicht handlungsfähig“. Die Diskussion fokussiert sich auf die Notwendigkeit radikaler Reformen und eines parteiübergreifenden Paktes, um den industriellen Abstieg und das „Tal des Todes“ der hiesigen Wirtschaft zu überwinden. (Quellen: „Deutschland ist politisch nicht handlungsfähig“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 17. April 2026; „Sachsen-Chef Kretschmer warnt; Deutschland steckt im „Tal des Todes“, bild.de, 15. April 2026; „Merz und Klingbeil müssten sich jetzt für eine Woche einschließen“, zeit.de, 17. April 2026.)
- **Die Neuausrichtung der Verteidigungsstrategie durch maritime Interessenwahrung:** Die Blockade der Straße von Hormus und die Bedrohung globaler Handelsrouten durch China und den Iran erzwingen eine Neubewertung der deutschen Militärstrategie. Bundeskanzler Merz bricht mit der Tradition der Zurückhaltung und bietet den Einsatz der Marine zur Sicherung der Seewege an. Die Debatte thematisiert die Fähigkeit Deutschlands, seine ökonomischen Abhängigkeiten im Notfall auch militärisch zu verteidigen, und markiert eine Abkehr vom reinen Multilateralismus hin zur „Sprache der Macht“. (Quellen: „Inspekteur der Marine; „Die richtigen Kämpfe führen“, wiwo.de, 17. April 2026; „Iran-Krieg; So will sich Deutschland an einer Marinemission beteiligen“, handelsblatt.com, 16. April 2026; „Abfuhr für Trump aus Brüssel“, faz.net, 17. März 2026.)
- **Der technologische Systemwettbewerb um „Physische KI“ und Roboter-Dominanz:** Deutschland wird in der Berichterstattung zunehmend als „Zuschauer“ im Rennen um die nächste Stufe der Künstlichen Intelligenz wahrgenommen. Während chinesische Firmen wie Unitree und Hesai bei humanoider Robotik und Lidar-Sensoren Weltmarktanteile von bis zu 60 Prozent erobern, warnen deutsche CEOs wie Roland Busch (Siemens) vor einer totalen Abhängigkeit. Die Diskussion dreht sich um die Frage, ob Deutschland durch radikale Deregulierung und Fokus auf industrielle KI den Anschluss noch halten kann. (Quellen: „Künstliche Intelligenz; „Wir müssen bei physischer KI jetzt All-in gehen“, wiwo.de, 19. März 2026; „Es geht für Lidar steil nach oben“, Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung, 16. April 2026; „Chinas



nächster KI-Hype; Die Software Openclaw revolutioniert den Arbeitsalltag“, Süddeutsche Zeitung, 14. April 2026.)

- **Die diplomatische Renaissance des Vatikans in der multipolaren Weltordnung:** Unter Papst Leo XIV. positioniert sich der Heilige Stuhl als eigenständiger, machtpolitischer Akteur, der sich deutlich von der US-Politik unter Trump und den Expansionsbestrebungen Chinas distanziert. In der deutschen Diskussion wird die moralische Autorität des Vatikans als notwendiges Korrektiv in einer Welt der Großmächte analysiert. Die Rolle des Papstes als Mediator, der auch vor Konflikten mit Washington nicht zurückweicht, wird als Stärkung einer unabhängigen europäischen Stimme begriffen. (Quellen: „PIERO SCHIAVAZZI; „Leo ist jetzt ein politischer Führer von Weltrang“, Handelsblatt, 15. April 2026; „Trump gegen Vatikan“, handelsblatt.com, 14. April 2026.)
- **Die Erosion des Patentstandorts Deutschland bei digitalen Schlüsseltechnologien:** Ein aktueller Bericht des Patentamts (DPMA) sorgt für Ernüchterung: Bei digitalen Zukunftstechnologien wie Halbleitern und KI liegt Deutschland in absoluten Zahlen weit hinter den USA und China zurück. Die Debatte thematisiert den strategischen Fehler, den Schutz geistigen Eigentums vernachlässigt zu haben, während China Wissen gezielt durch Rekrutierungen (Fall Huawei/Fraunhofer) absaugt. Es wird gefordert, Patente wieder als geostrategische Währung zu begreifen. (Quellen: „Schlüsseltechnologien; Patentamt: Deutschland holt in Digitaltechnik auf“, wiwo.de, 16. April 2026; „SORGE VOR WISSENS-ABFLUSS; Fraunhofer-Forscher wechselt zu Huawei“, Handelsblatt, 20. März 2026; „PATENTE; Deutsche Erfinder punkten bei KI“, Handelsblatt, 16. April 2026.)